# India's Leprosy Challenge

**GS II**

- A low national prevalence created the impression that leprosy was largely under control, but transmission continued in several areas. When **specialised surveillance** was merged with the general health system, detecting and tracking remaining cases became more difficult.

- Leprosy is also unevenly distributed across India. Some States and districts continue to carry a much higher disease burden, and cases among children show that **fresh transmission** is still occurring within communities.

- Late diagnosis allows the disease to cause greater harm and makes control more difficult. **Social stigma** can discourage people from seeking treatment, while limited knowledge among some healthcare workers can lead to leprosy being missed or mistaken for other skin conditions.

- India therefore needs to focus on stopping transmission rather than relying mainly on falling prevalence figures. Strong surveillance, **early detection**, treatment of patients and their contacts, and targeted action in high-burden areas are necessary to interrupt the spread.

***Leprosy control cannot be measured only by fewer registered cases. India must find infections early, reduce stigma and focus its efforts where transmission continues.***